France’s protests add to EU migration split

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GREETINGS. It’s Nick Vinocur. Let’s dive in.

In today’s Playbook:

— Liberal group leader Valérie Hayer has one key condition for backing Roberta Metsola.

— Europe has a new way to deal with Donald Trump’s shifts on Ukraine: ignore them.

— Faces in the crowd: Donald Tusk, Péter Magyar, Mette Frederiksen, Laurent Castillo, Andrej Babiš, António Costa, Manfred Weber, Emmanuel Macron and more …

On today’s Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Nick discuss why EU leaders can’t wait for the U.S. midterms to be over — and whether they have good reason to think things will change after they are.

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DRIVING THE DAY

FRANCE’S UNREST STOKES EUROPE’S MIGRATION FIGHT: Shock footage from protests in France over the weekend is pouring fuel onto a bitter European row over migration, with the leaders of Hungary and Poland warning that the chaos justifies their countries’ hardline policies.

Hungarian Prime Minister Péter Magyar said on X yesterday that the chaos that engulfed several French cities makes it “clear to everyone why Hungary advocates the strictest possible approach to migration.” U.S. President Donald Trump also weighed in, posting on Truth Social : “Close your Borders and take control, before it is too late!”

Polish PM Donald Tusk (though he didn’t mention the situation in France directly) joined the fray soon after with a defense of his own strict migration stance , posting: “Poland will not repeat the mistakes of other European countries, nor will it pay for them.”

The EU leaders' comments point to the increasing divisions on this issue around the European Council table heading into a pivotal election year. Magyar and Tusk were fresh from a debate on migration at last week's leaders' summit in Brussels that one diplomat described as "horrible."

Two EU diplomats, granted anonymity to discuss closed-door exchanges among leaders, said Friday's migration debate was "heated," "ugly," "very direct" and "not worthy of a European Council setting." One of the diplomats said that European Council President António Costa should have intervened to cut it short.

Accounts vary as to what was said, but the two diplomats agreed that Danish Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen and Czech Prime Minister Andrej Babiš used "highly charged language" linking migration policies to the "defense of European civilization." A third diplomat said the exchanges were impassioned but "political" and "necessary to bring the debate closer to voters' real concerns." A spokesperson for Czechia in Brussels declined to comment.

Rewind: The debate followed an attempt led by Denmark, Italy and Poland to sharply toughen language on migration in the summit's conclusions. The push won support from more than a dozen countries, according to three diplomats, but it was ultimately defeated when Emmanuel Macron, Luxembourgish Prime Minister Luc Frieden and Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez refused to sign on.

In that sense, yesterday's social media posts by Magyar and Tusk (both of whom backed the harder line) bring the tensions out into the open, just as EU leaders need to strike a deal on the bloc's long-term budget and funding for Ukraine.

The bottom line: Migration is a powder keg for Europe — even more so as leaders from France to Germany and Spain face emboldened right-wing and far-right challengers. Rioting and looting could provide the spark that brings them to power.

PARIS IS REELING: Macron appealed for calm in a national address last night, promising "full transparency" as his government investigates how mass demonstrations over the cost of living spiraled into arson, looting and clashes with the police. But the violence has given way to a fierce political debate over who is to blame, with the far-left accused of amplifying the unrest and Macron's administration blasted for losing control, Victor Goury-Laffont reports .

For Macron, the fallout isn't just domestic ⋯ the weekend's protests further weaken the French president's position around the European Council table, two diplomats told Playbook. "This just limits his ability to act," one of them said.

BIG AND BREAKING

THE COMING STORM: Europe is heading into a political maelstrom with elections looming in Spain, France and Italy amid high energy prices and spiraling economic prospects, Sebastian Starcevic reports.

INSIDE NATO'S WAR PLAN: The military alliance is beginning talks this month on what allies need to defend against a Russian attack — and how they would pay for it.

DIVERTED: An Austrian Airlines flight from Tel Aviv carrying 57 people was diverted to Sofia last night after a threat was made against the aircraft, Reuters reports .

FRANCE CONDEMNS WEST BANK ATTACK: France called on Israeli authorities to take “all necessary measures” to “stop these acts of terror” following an attack by masked Israeli settlers against European diplomats in the West Bank on Saturday, Jacopo Barigazzi reports .

WHY EUROPE’S PUSH TO SAVE NATURE IS FAILING: The EU’s Nature Restoration Law — once a flagship of its green rules — went from top priority to bogeyman with the help of two wars and an economic crisis, Marianne Gros reports .

LIBERALS GET TOUGH

NO COALITION DEAL, NO PRESIDENCY: Renew Europe chief Valérie Hayer told Playbook’s Max Griera the liberal group won’t support any candidate for Parliament president unless there’s a comprehensive coalition agreement with the European People’s Party and the Socialists and Democrats.

“A majority needs a program before it needs a president … and no coalition agreement would mean no leadership deal,” Hayer said. Although she didn’t name-check EPP incumbent Roberta Metsola, Hayer’s comments are a clear warning to the conservatives that if they want a third term, they’ll have to play ball. Read the full interview here .

Déjà vu: The three centrist group leaders signed a two-page deal committing to work with each other after the 2024 EU election, but the EPP has nonetheless occasionally voted with far-right groups, irking its partners.

What’s different this time? Hayer wants not only leaders but all “key members” of the groups, including vice chairs, whips and coordinators, to negotiate and endorse a deal.

What’s in the coalition? “I want us to be very concrete, I want a midterm agreement that binds us to delivery on the budget, on the IAA, for example, on EU Inc.,” Hayer said, referring to the Industrial Accelerator Act (a proposal to steer public procurement and subsidies toward European manufacturers) and a plan to give startups a single set of rules.

Homework: Hayer wants any presidential candidate to be hands-on to ensure the center holds because “you can’t say I’ve been elected and then I don’t care about the majority and the people who elected me.”

Hayer said the three centrist leaders have already discussed the idea and she is “confident” it would advance, though nothing is settled. Formal talks are expected after Hayer, the EPP’s Manfred Weber and the S&D’s Iratxe García are re-elected this week, though the real talks might only start after Spain’s Nov. 29 election, two EPP and S&D officials said.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

Now that the European Council is in the rearview mirror, the next scheduled meeting of EU leaders is an informal summit in Dublin on Nov. 13. But what is an informal summit? Sometimes referred to as retreats, informal summits allow for discussion but without adopting the formal, legally binding conclusions (documents setting out what the leaders have agreed on, or the common positions they have reached) that are issued at the end of formal summits.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked you to submit your birthday if you want a Playbook mention on the big day. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shout-out.

WAKE ME WHEN THE MIDTERMS END

READ THE ROOM: EU leaders, diplomats and officials have been talking down Donald Trump's latest pronouncements on Ukraine, arguing that he's playing to his audience back home — voters worried about the cost of living, Zoya Sheftalovich reports.

Trump's Republicans stand to lose the House and the Senate in the midterm elections on Nov. 3. That helps explain the president's diesel deal with Russia ⋯ his demands that Kyiv stop striking Russian oil refineries ⋯ and the administration's reported consideration of easing sanctions on Russia's shadow fleet .

"He's talking to Iowa," said one EU diplomat at the summit last week. "He's talking to Michigan and Ohio."

Stay calm and stay the course: Another diplomat said they've been cautioning their capital since August that Trump will keep lashing out until the midterms are over if it helps him win voters. An EU official said the bloc is now used to Trump's capricious Truth Social outbursts and will stay the course.

Trump's fall guy? Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy was asked during a press conference on Friday whether Trump is using him as a scapegoat for his political woes. There was a long pause. Then Zelenskyy smiled. "This is my answer," he said — and left the room. Watch the clip here .

Trump last night defended waiving sanctions on Russia and lashed out again at Zelenskyy, saying the Ukrainian President "doesn't want to end this war, and probably never did."

3 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

WHAT'S BEHIND A MAJOR CYBERATTACK ON SUPERMARKETS: A cyberattack that forced hundreds of retailers to throw away defrosted food and spoiled milk was mostly a reminder of the importance of old-school cybersecurity in safeguarding essential goods and services, Sam Clark and Ketrin Jochecová report .

TRUMP HELPS CHINA ON DRUG PRICING: Donald Trump wants to bring down medicine prices at home but his fight over drug pricing is likely to have an unexpected winner — China, Caroline Hug and Stephanie Bolzen report .

PATRIOTS LEVEL WITH ECR: Laurent Castillo's move to the French Senate leaves the Patriots for Europe and European Conservatives and Reformists each with 84 MEPs, and both right-wing groups are scouting for new members to become the third-biggest in the European Parliament. The ECR is expecting Branko Grims, expelled from the EPP, to join them, two people told Max Griera.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Mist in the morning changing to overcast. High of 15C.

GIG GUIDE: Some interesting musical treats in Brussels this week. Tomorrow at Botanique you can catch Turkish psychedelic weirdos (in the best possible way) Baba Zula ⋯ Also tomorrow, guitarists Thibaut Garcia and Antoine Morinière are at Flagey ⋯ South African pop star Tyla is at Forest National on Thursday ⋯ and French pop phenomenon Miki performs at Ancienne Belgique on Thursday (although that one's sold out, so you'll need to get yourself on the waiting list).

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Berlin's SPD is inching toward a power-sharing deal with the Greens and Left, but that's putting fresh strain on the party's federal coalition with Friedrich Merz's conservatives.

Paris: Emmanuel Macron's ministers will hold a series of crisis meetings in response to the weekend's mass unrest, after the president's national address last night fell flat.

London: Ahead of next week's budget, Andy Burnham is urging ministers to find "everyday fixes" to help convince voters the government is on their side.

Madrid: People's Party leader Alberto Núñez Feijóo will unveil a "contract" with voters today — and not for the first time.

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AGENDA

— The European Parliament plenary session opens in Strasbourg at 5 p.m. Watch live .

— European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and European Parliament President Roberta Metsola meet at 4:15 p.m.

— Metsola presides over the Parliament's Bureau meeting at 6 p.m.

— Von der Leyen meets the chairs of the European People's Party (Manfred Weber), Socialists and Democrats (Iratxe García) and Renew Europe (Valérie Hayer).

— EU employment and social affairs ministers meet in Luxembourg. Press conference around 4:15 p.m. Watch live .

— Commission Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto and Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis appear before the Parliament's Committee on Budgets and Committee on Economic and Monetary Affairs to discuss the track record of the EU's post-pandemic Recovery and Resilience Facility.

— Energy Commissioner Dan Jørgensen meets the Visegrad energy ministers to discuss energy prices and supply in Bratislava. Press conference around 11:30 a.m. Watch live .

— The EU formally signs association agreements with Andorra and San Marino. Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič, Andorra's Head of Government Xavier Espot Zamora and San Marino's Foreign Minister Luca Beccari take part in the signing ceremony.

— Migration Commissioner Magnus Brunner delivers the King's College London Centre of European Law's annual lecture, on the future of the EU's migration and asylum framework, at 7:30 p.m.

— Commission Executive Vice President Henna Virkkunen delivers a keynote speech at the Finnish Permanent Representation's EU-NATO event on defense innovation.

— Financial Services Commissioner Maria Luís Albuquerque presents the Commission's communication on banking competitiveness and the single market for banking to the European Banking Authority's Board of Stakeholders in Paris.

— Environment Commissioner Jessika Roswall takes part in an event in Leuven on the outcomes of the Structured Dialogue on Water, alongside Flemish Agriculture and Environment Minister Jo Brouns and a representative of Walloon Health and Environment Minister Yves Coppieters.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Marie-Luce Brasier-Clain; former MEPs Pierre Karleskind, Beata Mazurek and Pierre Larrouturou; POLITICO's Gavin Sundwall and Sarah Wheaton; Bloomberg's Giovanna Coi; Marco Uccelli of Treyst.ai; Mavence's Anna Aleksandra Koj.

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